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CUET UG

History

Social Histories of Early Societies: Mahabharata

Themes in Indian History (Part I) · Theme 3 · Class 12

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA History 314)	Skills the questions test
The Critical Edition	Critical Edition of the Mahabharata: V.S. Sukthankar project, textual variations, collation methodology	Historiographical timeline, editorial methods, source critique
Kinship & Marriage	Kinship rules, patriliny, forms of marriage (endogamy, exogamy, polygyny, polyandry), 8 types of marriage	Social anthropology concepts, textual analysis of Draupadi's marriage
The Gotra System	Gotra rules formulated c. 1000 BCE; Satavahana matronymics and deviations from orthodox exogamy	Epigraphic analysis of royal genealogy, gotra rules
Varna & Non-Kshatriya Kings	The 4-fold Varna order; non-Kshatriya kings (Shungas, Kanvas, Shakas, Satavahanas)	Evaluating shastric ideals against historical dynastic realities
Jatis & Outcastes	Jati multiplicity, silk weavers' guild at Mandasor, Nishadas, and Chandalas in Chinese travelogues	Social stratification, epigraphic reading of guilds, subaltern critique
Property & Buddhist Contract	Gendered access to property, Stridhana; Buddhist alternative of the social contract (**Mahasammata**)	Comparative social philosophy, economic rights of women

CUET Strategy & Exam Reality

- **Core Exam Pointers:** CUET UG frequently tests exact details: the duration of the Sukthankar Critical Edition project (1919–1966, 47 years), the Sanskrit terms for marriage types (**anuloma**, **pratiloma**, **exogamy**), Chinese travellers' accounts of Chandalas (Faxian and Xuanzang), the **Mandasor inscription** of silk weavers, and B.B. Lal's excavations at Hastinapura (1951–1952).
- **Analytical Balance:** Questions challenge candidates to contrast **prescriptive** Brahmanical literature (Dharmasutras and Manusmriti) with **descriptive** evidence from inscriptions and epics.

1. The Critical Edition of the Mahabharata

How do modern historians analyze an ancient epic that grew organically across more than a millennium?

In 1919, under the leadership of the distinguished Sanskrit scholar **V.S. Sukthankar**, an ambitious collective scholarship initiative was launched at the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute in Pune:

- **The Editorial Goal:** To reconstruct the earliest recoverable form of the colossal epic by collating all surviving palm-leaf and paper manuscripts written in diverse regional scripts (Sharada in Kashmir, Devanagari in the north, Bengali, Maithili, Odia, Telugu, Grantha, and Malayalam in the south).
- **Collation Methodology:** The team compared verses line by line, selecting only those lines that appeared identically across manuscripts preserved in both northern and southern scripts.
- **Monumental Duration:** The project took **47 years** to complete, culminating in 1966. The resulting Critical Edition spans **13,000 large pages** bound in dozens of volumes, containing over **100,000 verses**.

Two Revolutionary Findings

The Critical Edition permanently dismantled colonial assumptions that ancient Indian society was governed by uniform, rigid textual codes:

1. **Pervasive Subcontinental Core:** Striking commonalities existed in the central story of the Kuru-Pandava conflict across texts collected from Kashmir to Kerala.
2. **Enormous Regional Diversity:** More than half of the 13,000 pages consisted of footnotes and appendices documenting regional variations, localized episodes, and cultural adaptations. Early society was dynamic and pluralistic, marked by continuous dialogue between Brahmanical prescriptions and local customary practices.

2. Kinship and Marriage: Rules, Forms & Practices

Kinship ties (**kula** or family, **nati** or larger network of kin) formed the primary social fabric of early societies:

- **Patriliny (Pitrivamsha):** Tracing descent from father to son, grandson, and so on. Following a father's death, sons inherited family patrimony and royal titles. Under the Kuru dynasty, patriliny was contested violently in the Kurukshetra war between cousins (Kauravas and Pandavas).
- **Matriliny:** Tracing descent through the mother. Rare in northern monarchies, but evidenced in regional traditions and matrilineal naming practices.

Marriage Types & The Eight Forms in Manusmriti

Brahmanas established rigid rules regarding who could marry whom:

- **Endogamy:** Marriage within a single unit (kin group, caste, or locality). Widely practiced in south India among cross-cousins.
- **Exogamy:** Marriage outside one's unit (specifically outside one's gotra). Prescribed as mandatory by Brahmanical law.
- **Polygyny:** The practice of a man having multiple wives, common among ancient ruling aristocrats.

- **Polyandry:** The practice of a woman having multiple husbands. The most celebrated historical/literary example is **Draupadi's marriage to the five Pandava brothers**, which shocked King Drupada until sage Vyasa offered mythological justifications.

Classification	Marriage Forms (Manusmriti)	Legal Character & Moral Valuation
Approved Forms (**Dharmya**)	Forms 1 to 4 (Brahma, Daiva, Arsha, Prajapatya)	Regarded as praiseworthy; characterized by **Kanyadana** (the gift of a maiden adorned with ornaments/dowry by the father without receiving wealth).
Condemned Forms (**Adharmya**)	Forms 5 to 8 (Asura, Gandharva, Rakshasa, Paishacha)	Condemned by Brahmanas: Asura involved buying the bride; Gandharva was voluntary romantic union; Rakshasa involved abduction; Paishacha involved seduction of an intoxicated/sleeping woman.

3. The Gotra System & Satavahana Matronymics

From c. 1000 BCE, Brahmanas classified people (especially Brahmanas) into lineages called **gotras**, named after seven revered Vedic sages (**rishis** like Kashyapa, Gautama, Vashistha, Bharadvaja, Jamadagni, Vishvamitra, and Atri):

- **Two Mandatory Gotra Rules:**
  1. Women were expected to abandon their father's gotra and adopt their husband's gotra upon marriage.
  2. Members of the same gotra could not marry (**sagotra** marriage prohibition to preserve exogamy).

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Figure 1: Figure 1 — Kinship, Gender & Authority: Comparative 2×2 matrix contrasting orthodox Shastric rules against Satavahana epigraphy, polyandry, and the Buddhist social contract.

The Satavahana Subversion

Inscriptions from the **Satavahana dynasty** of the Deccan (c. 2nd century BCE to 2nd century CE) reveal direct deviations from Shastric norms:

- **Matronymics in Royal Titles:** Rulers derived their royal names from their mothers (**Gautamiputra Satakarni**, **Vashisthiputra Pulumayi**).
- **Retained Paternal Gotras:** Epigraphic evidence proves Satavahana queens retained their father's gotras (Gautama and Vashistha) after marriage, defying the rule of adopting the husband's gotra.
- **Endogamous Alliances:** Some queens belonged to the same gotra as their husbands, and marriages between cross-cousins (maternal uncle's daughter) were customary, directly flouting Brahmanical exogamy.

THE CONSTITUTIONAL LAW VS CUSTOMARY REALITY

Think of the Dharmashastras like an idealized legal constitution drafted by elite scholars: it describes how society **ought** to behave in theory. But real human kingdoms, like modern customary societies, frequently followed their own ancestral traditions that completely bypassed formal legal codes.

4. The Varna Order & Non-Kshatriya Kings

The Brahmanical social hierarchy was grounded in the **Purusha Sukta** of the Rigveda, which asserted that the four varnas originated from the cosmic person's body:

- **Brahmanas:** Priests and teachers (originating from the mouth).
- **Kshatriyas:** Rulers and warriors (originating from the arms).
- **Vaishyas:** Farmers, traders, and cattle-herders (originating from the thighs).
- **Shudras:** Servants of the upper three varnas (originating from the feet).

The Historical Reality: Who Actually Ruled?

According to Shastras, only Kshatriyas had the divine right to rule. However, historical and epigraphic records demonstrate that almost anyone possessing military power and economic resources seized kingship:

Dynasty	Claimed / Textual Origin	Historical & Social Implication
Mauryan Dynasty	Brahmanical texts call them of "low origin" (**shudra-praya**); Buddhist texts call them Kshatriyas	Proves political power depended on popular charisma and military force, not pure varna birth.
Shunga and Kanva Dynasties	Brahmanas	Immediate successors of the Mauryas were high-caste Brahmanas who seized the throne by military coups.
Shaka Dynasty	Central Asian invaders (**Mlechchhas** / barbarians)	Regarded as uncivilized foreigners, yet Saka king Rudradaman patronized classical Sanskrit and restored Sudarshana Lake.
Satavahana Dynasty	Gautamiputra Satakarni claimed to be **Eka Bamhana** ("unique Brahmana")	Claimed to destroy the pride of Kshatriyas, yet established matrimonial ties with the barbarian Shaka family.

5. Jatis, Guilds & The Limits of Varna

While the number of **varnas** was strictly fixed at four, there was no numerical restriction on **jatis** (occupational groups, tribes, and craft communities):



Figure 2: Figure 2 — Social Order: Shastric Varna ideal contrasted with historical Jati multiplicity, silk-weavers' guild at Mandasor, and outcaste Chandalas.

The Mandasor Inscription: Silk Weavers' Guild

An extraordinary 5th-century CE stone inscription found at **Mandasor** (ancient Dashapura in Madhya Pradesh) documents social mobility within a jati:

- **Guild Migration:** A corporation of silk weavers (**reshama-vanik**) migrated from **Lata** (southern Gujarat) to Dashapura, attracted by the enlightened rule of the local king.
- **Occupational Fluidity:** Although unified as a craft guild, individual members diversified: some became archers and military commanders, others took up astronomy, story-telling, or asceticism.
- **Monumental Piety:** The guild pooled its collective commercial wealth to construct and later renovate a magnificent stone temple dedicated to the Sun God (**Surya**).

Populations Beyond the Varna Framework

Brahmanas viewed groups living beyond agrarian settlements with deep prejudice:

- **Nishadas (Forest Dwellers):** Hunter-gatherers and forest nomads were viewed as uncivilized. In the Mahabharata, the low-born forest archer **Ekalavya** mastered archery by worshipping an earthen idol of Drona; Drona demanded his right thumb as **gurudakshina** to guarantee the royal Kshatriya prince Arjuna remained peerless.
- **Mlechchhas:** Nomadic and Central Asian groups speaking unfamiliar non-Sanskrit languages were labeled barbarians (**Mlechchhas**).
- **Chandalas (Untouchables):** Assigned the lowest degraded status, forced to live outside villages, handle corpses, execute condemned criminals, and wear clothes of the dead.

- Chinese Buddhist pilgrim **Faxian (5th century CE)** wrote that Chandalas entering a city had to strike wooden clappers (**talas**) so passersby could avert their eyes from pollution.
- **Xuanzang (7th century CE)** recorded that butchers, executioners, and scavengers were permanently segregated beyond city ramparts.

6. Beyond Birth: Gendered Property, Stridhana & Buddhist Critique

How did early societies distribute material wealth along gender and caste lines?

Gendered Property Rights in Manusmriti

- **Paternal Estate:** After the father's death, ancestral land and cattle were divided equally among sons, with a special supplementary share reserved for the eldest son.
- **Exclusion of Daughters:** Daughters could not claim any share of family land.
- **Stridhana (Woman's Wealth):** Gifts given to a bride at her wedding (jewelry, clothes) were recognized as her **Stridhana**. Her children could inherit this property without the husband claiming ownership.
- **Injunction Against Hoarding:** The Manusmriti explicitly cautioned women against hoarding family property or hiding valuables without their husband's permission.
- **Elite Royal Exceptions:** As seen in the **Danguna copper plate**, queen regent **Prabhavati Gupta** possessed independent authority to donate land and revenue, proving royal status could override gender disabilities.

The Buddhist Challenge to Varna Hegemony

Buddhism recognized that social differences existed, but firmly denied that social status was divinely determined by birth:

- **The Majjhima Nikaya Dialogue:** In an ancient Pali text, King Avantiputta of Madhura questioned the Buddhist elder **Mahakachchana** about the Brahmana claim of being the superior caste. Kachchana demonstrated that an affluent Shudra could hire a Brahmana as a servant: economic wealth, not birth, dictated actual social deference.
- **Bhikshu Equality:** Upon ordination into the Buddhist Sangha, all caste titles were erased, just as individual rivers lose their names when merging into the great ocean.

7. A Social Contract: The Buddhist Mahasammata Alternative

How did ancient thinkers explain the origin of state authority without divine intervention?

While Brahmanical texts derived kingship from divine cosmic will (the king as an incarnation of eight guardian deities), the Buddhist canonical text **Sutta Pitaka** provided a rational social contract theory:

- **The Primordial Golden Age:** Myth relates that human beings initially lived in a state of idyllic innocence, taking only as much food from nature as needed for each meal.
- **Human Greed and Decay:** Over time, greed entered society; individuals began hoarding grain and claiming private ownership of land. Theft, falsehood, and violence erupted.

- **The Election of Mahasammata:** Exhausted by disorder, humanity gathered and elected the most capable, handsome, and virtuous man among them to enforce law and punish wickedness.
- **The Fiscal Compact:** In return for maintaining civil order, the elected leader (**Mahasammata**, meaning "the great chosen one") was paid a voluntary levy of one-sixth of the grain harvest.
- **Significance:** This early Indian text conceptualized kingship as a human institution founded on mutual consent and taxation, not divine ordination.

8. Handling Texts: Historians, Language, Dynamic Traditions & Hastinapura

The Mahabharata was not a dead manuscript; it was a living, evolving tradition:

- **Language of the Epic:** Written in simple, accessible classical Sanskrit, far more comprehensible than the complex Vedic hymns, ensuring wide recitation across society.
- **Two Components:**
  - **Narrative:** Dramatic storytelling, war chronicles, and familial disputes (**katha**).
  - **Didactic:** Ethical, moral, and philosophical discourses (e.g., the **Bhagavad Gita** delivered by Krishna to Arjuna on the battlefield, interpolated c. 200 BCE to 200 CE).
- **Authorship Evolution:**
  1. Originally composed and sung orally by bardic charioteers (**sutas**) who accompanied warriors to battle.
  2. From c. 5th century BCE, Brahmanas committed the tales to writing, infusing religious and legal norms.
  3. Between c. 200 BCE and 400 CE, massive didactic expansions occurred, bringing the epic to 100,000 verses traditionally ascribed to the sage **Vyasa**.

B.B. Lal's Excavations at Hastinapura (1951–1952)

Between 1951 and 1952, Indian archaeologist **B.B. Lal** excavated the ancient mound of **Hastinapura** in Meerut district, Uttar Pradesh:

- **Stratigraphic Discoveries:** Five distinct occupational periods were uncovered.
- **Period II (c. 12th to 7th century BCE):** Corresponded to the Painted Grey Ware (PGW) culture. Houses were built of mud-brick and wattle-and-daub (reed walls plastered with thick mud).
- **Period III (c. 6th to 3rd century BCE):** Revealed mud-brick and baked-brick structures, soakage pits, and terracotta ring wells, confirming gradual urbanization mirroring epic descriptions.

Key Facts & Terms: One-Stop Revision



Figure 3: Figure 3 — Early Societies & The Mahabharata Topic Summary Mindmap: Complete synthesis of the Critical Edition, kinship, gotra deviations, varna realities, property, and textual historiography.

- **V.S. Sukthankar:** Leader of the Mahabharata Critical Edition project (1919–1966).
- **Patriliny:** Tracing descent and inheritance from father to son (**pitrivamsha**).
- **Endogamy:** Marriage practice of seeking a spouse within one's own kin group or locality.
- **Exogamy:** Marriage practice of seeking a spouse outside one's kin group/gotra.
- **Polyandry:** Marital arrangement where one woman has several husbands (e.g., Draupadi).
- **Polygyny:** Marital arrangement where one man has several wives (e.g., Satavahana kings).
- **Gotra:** Exogamous clan lineage named after a Vedic rishi, formulated c. 1000 BCE.
- **Matronymic:** Name derived from that of the mother (e.g., Gautamiputra).
- **Stridhana:** Woman's bridal wealth gifted at marriage, exempt from husband's division.
- **Mahasammata:** "The great chosen one", first contractual monarch in Buddhist political mythology.

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Sukthankar's project took 10 years	Underestimating the colossal collation effort	The Critical Edition took **47 years** to complete (1919 to 1966), spanning 13,000 pages.

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Satavahana society was matrilineal	Confusing matronymics with inheritance rules	Satavahana rulers used **matronymics**, but succession to the throne was strictly **patrilineal** (father to son).
Polyandry was the universal norm in ancient India	Generalizing an exceptional epic episode	Polyandry was a rare, regional exception; **patrilineal exogamy** was the dominant normative standard.
Manusmriti permitted daughters equal land rights	Applying modern equality to ancient Shastras	Manusmriti barred daughters from ancestral land; women only held **Stridhana** (bridal jewelry and gifts).
Hastinapura was excavated by John Marshall	Mixing Indus excavators with PGW archaeologists	**B.B. Lal** excavated Hastinapura in 1951–1952, identifying Painted Grey Ware levels.

15 High-Yield CUET Practice Questions

Q1. The ambitious project to prepare a Critical Edition of the Mahabharata was initiated in 1919 under the leadership of which scholar?

(A) B.B. Lal
(B) V.S. Sukthankar
(C) R.E.M. Wheeler
(D) James Prinsep

Q2. How many years did the editorial committee take to complete the Critical Edition of the Mahabharata?

(A) 25 years
(B) 35 years
(C) 47 years
(D) 52 years

Q3. Which form of marriage refers to the practice of a woman having several husbands simultaneously?

(A) Endogamy
(B) Exogamy
(C) Polygyny
(D) Polyandry

Q4. According to the Brahmanical gotra rules formulated c. 1000 BCE, which of the following was strictly prohibited?

(A) Adopting the husband's gotra upon marriage
(B) Marriage between individuals of the same gotra
(C) Naming gotras after Vedic rishis
(D) Women retaining their father's gotra after death

Q5. Which ancient dynasty's rulers were famously identified through matronymics, such as Gautamiputra and Vashisthiputra?

(A) Guptas
(B) Mauryas
(C) Satavahanas
(D) Kushanas

Q6. The Mandasor stone inscription of the 5th century CE records the migration and socio-religious activities of which craft guild?

(A) Ivory-carvers of Vidisha
(B) Silk weavers of Lata
(C) Goldsmiths of Ujjayini
(D) Blacksmiths of Pataliputra

Q7. According to the Manusmriti, which category of marriage forms was regarded as 'dharmya' (praiseworthy)?

(A) First two forms only
(B) First four forms
(C) Fifth and sixth forms
(D) All eight forms equally

Q8. Which famous forest dweller (Nishada) in the Mahabharata had his right thumb demanded as gurudakshina by Dronacharya?

(A) Sanjaya
(B) Ekalavya
(C) Vidura
(D) Ghatotkacha

Q9. The Chinese Buddhist pilgrim Faxian noted that which oppressed social group had to strike a piece of wood when entering a city?

(A) Brahmanas
(B) Mlechchhas
(C) Chandalas
(D) Nishadas

Q10. What was the special term used in the Manusmriti for a woman's separate bridal property, gifted to her at the time of marriage?

(A) Agrahara
(B) Stridhana
(C) Bhoga
(D) Kanyadana

Q11. In the Buddhist Pali text Sutta Pitaka, what title was given to the first mythical monarch elected by human consensus to enforce order?

(A) Devaputra
(B) Mahasammata
(C) Chakravartin
(D) Samaharta

Q12. The ancient mound of Hastinapura in Uttar Pradesh was excavated in 1951–1952 by which prominent Indian archaeologist?

(A) Daya Ram Sahni
(B) B.B. Lal
(C) S.R. Rao
(D) A. Ghosh

Q13. Who was the Satavahana ruler who claimed to be the 'unique Brahmana' (Eka Bamhana) and the destroyer of Kshatriya pride?

(A) Simuka
(B) Gautamiputra Satakarni
(C) Vashisthiputra Pulumayi
(D) Yajna Sri Satakarni

Q14. Which section of the Mahabharata contains moral, philosophical, and social instruction, such as the Bhagavad Gita?

(A) Narrative section
(B) Didactic section
(C) Katha section
(D) Vamsha section

Q15. The dialogue between King Avantiputta and the Buddhist disciple Mahakachchana in the Majjhima Nikaya was meant to demonstrate what?

(A) That Brahmanas were naturally superior by divine birth
(B) That economic wealth, not varna, determined social deference
(C) That all kings must renounce their thrones
(D) That sacrifices were mandatory for spiritual liberation

Solutions & Detailed Explanations

Sol. Q1. In 1919, the eminent Sanskrit scholar **V.S. Sukthankar** led a team of researchers at the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute in Pune to prepare the authoritative Critical Edition of the Mahabharata.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q2. The colossal Critical Edition project commenced in 1919 and was completed in 1966, taking **47 years** of painstaking collation across 13,000 pages of text.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q3. Polyandry is the marriage custom in which a woman has more than one husband simultaneously. The Mahabharata famously features polyandry in Draupadi's union with the five Pandavas.

Answer: (D)

Sol. Q4. Brahmanical gotra rules dictated that members of the same gotra could never marry each other (**sagotra** prohibition), requiring exogamy.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q5. **Satavahana** rulers of the Deccan derived names from their mothers (**matronymics**), though royal succession to the throne remained strictly patrilineal.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q6. The 5th-century CE Mandasor inscription documents a guild of **silk weavers** (**reshama-vanik**) who migrated from Lata in Gujarat to Dashapura (Mandasor) and built a Sun temple.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q7. The Manusmriti classifies eight forms of marriage: the **first four forms** were considered **dharmya** (praiseworthy), while the remaining four were condemned as adharmya.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. **Ekalavya**, a Nishada (forest hunter), was forced to sacrifice his right thumb to Dronacharya to preserve the Kshatriya prince Arjuna's supreme martial standing.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q9. Chinese pilgrim **Faxian** recorded that **Chandalas** (deemed untouchable corpse-handlers) were forced to strike a piece of wood when entering street gates so that high-caste citizens could avoid pollution.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q10. **Stridhana** (literally "woman's wealth") was the property gifted to a woman on the occasion of her marriage, which could be inherited by her children without interference from the husband.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q11. In the Buddhist **Sutta Pitaka**, the first king chosen by human consensus to maintain social order in return for a rice tax was titled **Mahasammata** ("the great chosen one").

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q12. **B.B. Lal** excavated the epic site of Hastinapura in Meerut district between 1951 and 1952, identifying Painted Grey Ware (PGW) strata.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q13. **Gautamiputra Satakarni** (c. 2nd century CE) claimed in his mother Gautami Balashri's Nasik prashasti to be the **Eka Bamhana** ("peerless Brahmana") and the crusher of Kshatriya pride.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q14. The Mahabharata is classified into two main streams: the **narrative** (stories, dramatic war accounts) and the **didactic** (moral, religious, and legal instructions, such as the Bhagavad Gita).

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q15. In the **Majjhima Nikaya**, the sage Mahakachchana proved to King Avantiputta that a rich Shudra could command servants from all varnas, demonstrating that social power stems from economic wealth rather than divine birth.

Answer: (B)

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